

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Sir Keir Starmer is facing calls to resign after his Labour Party received a drubbing in Britain's [local elections](#) on Thursday, losing hundreds of seats, mostly to populist outfits. Some leaders might have responded by bringing in fresh blood. Not Sir Keir. He appointed **Gordon Brown**, a former prime minister, to advise him on finance and **Harriet Harman**, a former shadow deputy prime minister, to advise him on women's rights.

Vladimir Putin defended his “just” war in **Ukraine** during the **Victory Day** parade in Moscow. Russia's president accused Ukraine of violating a three-day ceasefire, which started on Saturday, but did not explain how. The annual celebration of the Soviet Union's victory over Nazi Germany was an unusually modest affair for fear of a [Ukrainian attack](#). The Kremlin also turned off Moscow's internet.

Peter Magyar took office as **Hungary's prime minister**, bringing to an end Viktor Orban's decade and a half in power. The [new government](#) has vowed to return Hungary to the European fold. It hopes to unlock European Union funding that had been paused in response to Mr Orban's autocratic governance.

An **oil spill** was detected west of Kharg Island, site of Iran's main petroleum export terminal. Based on satellite imagery, Orbital EOS, a monitoring service, estimated that the oil could have spread over 20 square miles (52 square kilometres), raising concerns about leaky Iranian infrastructure. Earlier, America said that it expected **Iran** to respond imminently to its proposal to [end the war](#).

India appointed ^{NS} Raja Subramani, a retired general, to be its **new defence chief**, as the country continued to revamp its armed forces. Mr Subramani will be tasked with bringing together the country's huge, often disparate forces under a more centralised command. The navy also appointed a new boss, Krishna Swaminathan.

Virginia's top court ruled 4-3 against implementing a new **congressional map** that [voters approved last month](#). Under the map, Democrats might have won up to four new seats in the House of Representatives in November's midterm elections. But the justices took issue with the timing of when the proposal was added to the ballot. Mr Trump called the decision a "huge win" for Republicans.

The Pentagon declassified a batch of files on "[Unidentified Anomalous Phenomena](#)"—or **ufos**. The Trump administration said more material would be published on a rolling basis, touting the move as one of "unprecedented transparency". The release included supposed eye-witness accounts of unusual objects, as well as dozens of blurry images. Alien-watchers might be disappointed.

Word of the week: Mirror life, synthetic organisms built from mirror-image versions of natural molecules, which could potentially enable a new [era of bioterrorism](#).



Photograph: Reuters

America and China's mutual suspicion

When leaders meet at a summit, they often celebrate increased trade between their countries. But when President Donald Trump visits his Chinese counterpart next week in Beijing, he may instead reflect with satisfaction on the [increased economic distance](#) between the two economies. Thanks in part to his tariffs, China's exports to America fell by 10.2% year on year in the first four months of 2026, narrowing the trade imbalance between the countries.

The Iran war that Mr Trump started, but seems unable to finish, has also hurt China's trade with the Middle East. Despite these setbacks, its exports have boomed. Trade figures released on Saturday showed that they grew by more than 14% year on year in April. America wants to shed its dependence on Chinese suppliers. Meanwhile China is reducing its dependence on American buyers.



Photograph: AP

Parade's End

Victory Day—celebrated on May 9th, the anniversary of the Soviet Union's victory over Nazism—is the holiest day in [Vladimir Putin's](#) religion of war. A military parade in Red Square is its most important rite. Mr Putin likes to portray Russia's invasion of Ukraine as a sequel to the second world war. The parade is meant to suggest the inevitability of another victory.

But this year's celebrations have been scaled down, turning them instead into a display of vulnerability. For the first time in two decades there will be no military vehicles rumbling through Red Square. Russia fears long-range Ukrainian attacks on the parade: a shortened running time and (even more) internet restrictions are meant to mitigate this risk. (Moscow has vowed to retaliate for any such attack with a “massive missile strike” on the heart of Kyiv, Ukraine's capital.) Ukraine was unlikely to take action, and on Friday Donald Trump announced a three-day ceasefire between the two countries. But the symbolic damage has already been inflicted.



Photograph: Reuters

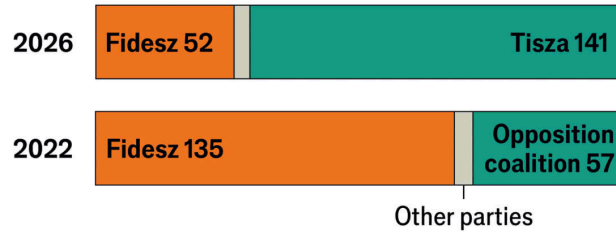
Hungary after Orban

Last month Hungarian voters dealt a crushing blow to Viktor Orban's 16-year populist rule, electing Peter Magyar and his centre-right Tisza party in [a landslide](#). On Saturday this new era begins. Mr Magyar will take his oath of office as prime minister, the same day that Hungary's new parliament convenes for the first time. Several anthems will be played, including the unofficial track of the country's Roma citizens, who number up to 875,000, or 8% of the population. Mr Magyar has also planned a "System Change" celebration in Budapest's Kossuth square.

[Gargantuan challenges loom](#) once the festivities are over. Mr Magyar and his Tisza government must re-establish Hungary's rule of law and dismantle the system of corrupt cronyism built by Mr Orban. They will also need to rebuild Hungary's reputation as a reliable EU and NATO partner. The hard part starts on Monday.

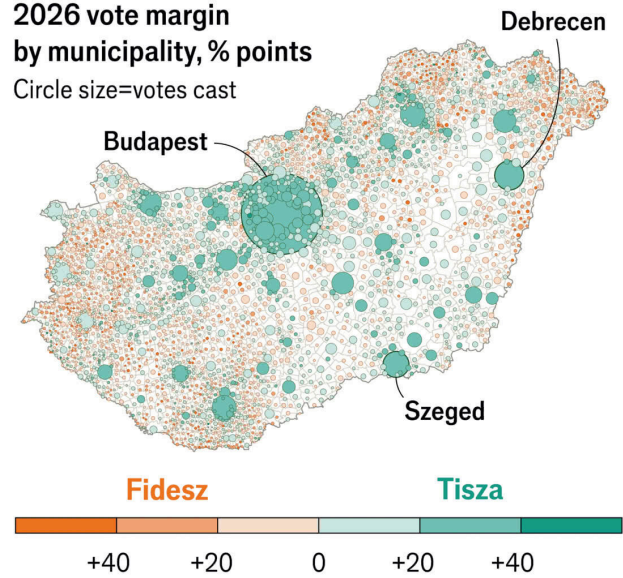
An idol falls

Hungarian elections, parliamentary seats won



2026 vote margin
by municipality, % points

Circle size=votes cast



Source: National Elections Office



Photograph: ROPI

The world's top art show gets political

The Venice Biennale, the world's leading contemporary-art exhibition, opens to the public on Saturday. But its [readmission of Russia](#) for the first time since the country invaded Ukraine in 2022 is proving [intensely controversial](#). When Russia's pavilion opened earlier this week it attracted swarms of protesters clad in pink balaclavas and armed with colourful smoke. Even before the demonstrations Russia's building was set to close once previews ended on Friday, with performances being screened outside.

Russia's inclusion has reignited the debate over art, politics and violence. Pietrangelo Buttafuoco, the festival's president, has argued that disagreements should happen "within a shared space". Meanwhile, the European Commission has warned the fair that it is violating EU sanctions. The dispute has also highlighted the split among Italy's populist right. Giorgia Meloni, the prime minister, who supports Ukraine, has decried Russia's inclusion. But Matteo Salvini, her coalition partner who has often expressed admiration for Vladimir Putin, has backed it.



Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Vijay, the action hero who conquered India's economic powerhouse

“A lion only comes out to hunt; it never comes out to just look around,” thundered Vijay. The mononymous south Indian movie star has issued countless such warnings to his foes (before duly dispatching them) over the course of 76 Tamil films. This threat, however, was delivered not on screen, but at a political rally in Tamil Nadu, where he was campaigning for state elections.

The theatrical language worked. On May 4th Vijay's party, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), won the state's vote, toppling a 59-year duopoly of regional parties. Vijay still needs to cobble together a coalition, but in the coming days the 51-year-old is expected to become chief minister. That is hugely consequential. Tamil Nadu is India's fastest-growing economy, home to 78m people as well as Apple factories and much of the country's automotive industry.

Tamil Nadu's movie industry has long been a screen test for local politicians: nearly every chief minister over the past six decades [has been connected to it](#). Vijay, though, was raised inside it. At just ten years old his father, a director, cast him in his first film. His later all-action roles turned him into what Tamils call a “mass hero” (ie, beloved by the masses). Anointed “the commander” by his fans, on screen he foiled terrorists, battled land-grabbing tycoons

and exposed electoral fraud on screen. In one film he wrestled a hyena with his bare hands to a pulsating soundtrack.

Vijay's legions of devoted fans came to believe he could be the real-life hero he played. His acolytes organised themselves in loud and energetic fan clubs, which make ideal political vehicles. Turning them towards TVK required mere consolidation and rebranding.

TVK claims to stand for social justice, egalitarianism and Tamil pride. Vijay, a Catholic, has called the Hindu-nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party, which runs India, his "ideological opponent", and lambasted its treatment of minorities. He dismissed Tamil Nadu's previous rulers as corrupt and dynastic. These allegations resonated with voters—especially youngsters.

TVK has promised to fulfil its ideology through an assortment of welfare schemes. But how a party of novices does this is unclear. And Vijay will have to govern in a coalition while contending with the two influential parties he dispatched to the opposition. Rumours swirl that the bitter rivals might even ally to unseat him. In the jungle of politics, every beast is hunting the lion.

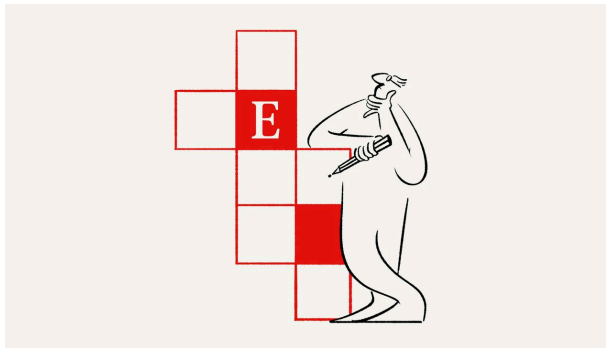


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Wired and beaten one-nil (6)

2 across - Gamble on border (5)

3 across - Shout in pain, colourfully? (6)

1 down - Watching The Birds trilogy? Oh no! Horrific! (11)

Straight clues

1 across - Connected to the internet (6)

2 across - Shrubbery used as boundary (5)

3 across - Sunny hue; song by Coldplay (6)

1 down - The study of avian anatomy, behaviour, etc (11)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Elena Zăvoianu in Leuven, Belgium

Emilio Ferreira in Buenos Aires, Argentina

Lee Brownfield in El Paso, Texas

They gave the correct answers of Pink Floyd, Creedence Clearwater Revival, The Police, R.E.M and Andy Williams. The theme is that they had hit songs or albums about the moon: The Dark Side of the Moon, Bad Moon Rising, Walking on the Moon, Man on the Moon and Moon River.

The questions were:

Monday: Which prog rock group was founded by Syd Barrett, Nick Mason, Roger Waters and Richard Wright?

Tuesday: John Fogerty was the main songwriter of which rock group?

Wednesday: Andy Summers was the guitarist of which British rock band?

Thursday: Michael Stipe is the lead singer of which band from Athens, Georgia?

Friday: Which easy-listening singer had a long-running TV show in the 1960s and later established his own theatre in Branson, Missouri?

Life is a long lesson in humility.

J. M. Barrie